

THE BUSINESS OF BELONGING

Here's how the Dallas Cowboys built a USD 10 billion-global **sports empire** through innovative marketing, stadium economics, and fan loyalty, despite a 30-year championship drought, offering blueprint lessons for India and the FIFA World Cup 2026.

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When Sachin Tendulkar walked into the home of the Dallas Cowboys in 2024, the visit created the sort of ripple that travelled well beyond Texas. In India, social media lit up at the sight of the country's most beloved sporting icon inside the orbit of American football's most valuable team.

For Charlotte Jones, the Cowboys' Executive Vice President and Chief Brand Officer, the fascination ran deeper than celebrity. Tendulkar offered a way of understanding what sporting institutions can mean to people. Not just as teams or athletes, but as carriers of memory, belonging and identity across generations. That idea now sits at the heart of Dallas's FIFA World Cup summer, with the Cowboys' stadium hosting nine matches and becoming one of the tournament's defining venues.

Charlotte still lights up at the mention of Tendulkar's visit, which was organised by Arun Agarwal-run National Cricket League, where Tendulkar is a co-owner and mentor.

"It was so fun," she says.

But what lingered was less the novelty of the crossover and more the scale of the man's cultural presence. The Cowboys, she explains, made a strategic choice long ago not to let any one player solely define the organisation because stars leave and franchises must outlive them.

Tendulkar represented the opposite kind of phenomenon. An individual who had become

an institution in his own right.

"I can read the story about who he is and the impact he has," she says, "but if I relate it to the impact that I know we have, then I could appreciate what one man has done."

That, in a way, is the best starting point for understanding both Charlotte and the Cowboys. For most of the sporting world, the Dallas Cowboys are introduced with a familiar line: the world's most valuable sports franchise.

It is a title that carries glamour, but also a certain paradox. The Cowboys have not won a Super Bowl since the 1990s. In purely sporting terms, they are not a modern dynasty. Yet in business, cultural reach and symbolic weight, they remain one of the biggest institutions in world sport.

Charlotte is one of the most powerful women in American sport, but also one of the most important interpreters of what the Cowboys have become. She is both an executive, co-owner and one of the faces of the organisation.

Her responsibilities span brand, fan engagement and business strategy, and her influence extends well beyond the NFL through her role as chair of the NFL Foundation.

Yet the most revealing thing about speaking to her in the middle of a World Cup summer is not how much she talks about football, but